Full Physical Exam Practice Checklist

Use this as a head-to-toe practice guide for a routine adult physical exam. Adapt to the clinical context.

Competent: *Demonstrate all elements correctly*

Proficient: *Complete all elements in 9-10 minutes*

Expert: *Complete all elements in 6-7 minutes*

1) General Survey (Position: Stand)

- Assess
  - Overall appearance (distress, work of breathing, ill vs. well)
  - Level of consciousness/orientation (A&O if appropriate)
  - Skin color/perfusion; hydration
- Inspect
  - Posture, gait, balance
  - Toe/heel walk
- General ROM
  - Neck
  - Back
  - Shoulder (Apley's scratch test)
  - Hips/Knees/Ankles (Squat)

2) Head, Eyes, Ears, Nose, Throat (Position: Sit)

- Inspect
  - Face/scalp
  - External eyes/ears/nose
  - Conjunctivae/sclera
  - Eyes PERRL (with light source, **CN II**)
  - Eye movement (up/down/left/right/converge, **CN III, IV, VI**)
  - Facial nerve (smile, puff cheeks, **CN VII**)
- Palpate
  - Face (**CN V: Sensory**, 3 branches)
- Inspect
  - Internal ear: otoscopic exam (canal/TM)
  - gross hearing (whisper/rubbing fingers, **CN VIII**)
- Inspect
  - Lips, tongue, gums, oropharynx (with light source)
  - Say "ah" to lift soft palate (**CN IX, X**)

    - Tongue protrusion (**CN XII**)
- Palpate
    - Resisted shoulder shrug or neck turn (**CN XI**)
- Inspect
    - Neck
- Palpate
    - Thyroid
    - Anterior and posterior neck for lymphadenopathy
- Auscultate
    - Carotid arteries

3) Chest

(Note: inspection for breathing typically done as general survey, but don't forget inspection)

- Auscultate
    - Anterior and posterior lung fields (compare side-to-side), at least 2 levels on each side
    - Cardiac listening posts: aortic, pulmonic, tricuspid, mitral (note rate/rhythm, S1/S2, extra sounds, murmurs)
- Palpate
    - back
    - radial pulses, compare bilateral pulses if relevant

4) Extremities/MSK/Neuro Screen

- Palpate/Test
    - Muscle strength of arms (Push, pull, squeeze)
    - Muscle strength of legs (Lift knee, push lower leg, pull lower leg)
- Edema assessment (pitting/non-pitting) ankles/shins
- Test reflexes
    - Biceps (**C5, C6**)
    - Patellar (**L2-L4**)

5) Abdomen (Position: Supine, knees slightly flexed; drape appropriately)

- Inspect
    - Abdomen
- Auscultate
    - Abdomen
- Palpate
    - Light then deep in all 4 quadrants